Community Living for People with Disabilities: Access to Housing

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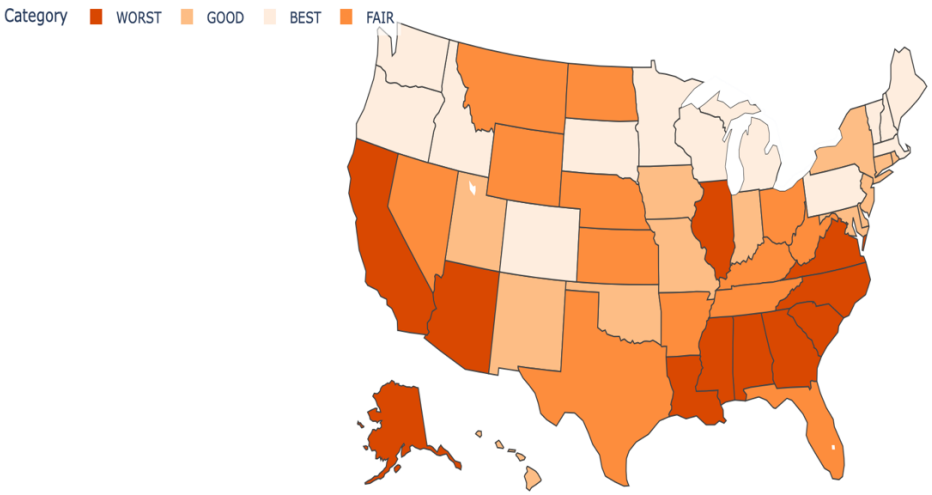
The Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA) mandates the right to live in the community with supports for people with disabilities instead of living in a nursing home. Similarly, the Fair Housing Act (FHA) expands on this right by prohibiting discrimination against people with disabilities by landlords and other housing providers. Despite this right to live in the community, people with disabilities face many difficulties in finding affordable and accessible housing.

Finding and securing housing is a challenge for people with disabilities, as they are far more likely to live in poverty than their non-disabled peers. Additionally, despite protections from the ADA and FHA, people with disabilities still face a great amount of discrimination from landlords, making it increasingly difficult for people with disabilities to find housing in the community. Supports such as the Section 8 Housing Choice Voucher program (HCV) and the availability of public housing are meant to alleviate the difficulties people with disabilities, the elderly, and people with low incomes face in securing affordable housing. [1]

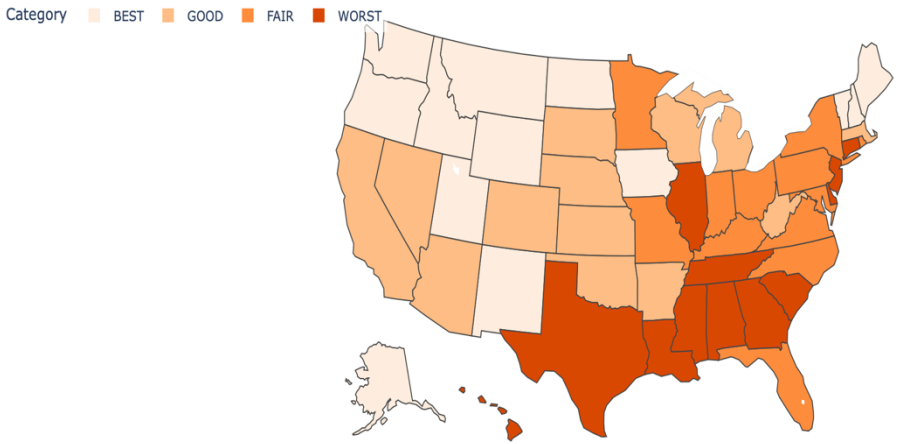
One way people with disabilities can access affordable housing is through public housing structures consisting of housing units affordable to people with low incomes. Alternatively, Section 8 Housing Choice vouchers (HCV) provide community rental assistance to households, allowing for greater choice and access to available rental units regardless of location. Both public housing and HCVs increase access to housing; HCVs allow for greater choice and opportunity.

Some states are doing better than others to ensure access to HCVs and public housing for people with disabilities. The map on the right shows the percentage of Housing Choice Voucher recipients whose head of household is a person with a disability. The map on the left shows the percentage of public housing units whose head of household is a person with a disability. States shown in a lighter color have a higher percentage of housing support going to heads of households with a disability. To honor the ADA and its mandates of inclusion, states must work to increase the representation of people with disabilities in their housing support. This is especially true of the Housing Choice Voucher program, as it provides the greatest access to the community and respects people with disabilities' right to live in accessible, affordable, and integrated housing.

Public Housing: % of Heads of Household with a Disability



Housing Choice Vouchers: % of Heads of Household with a Disability



To explore the interactive version of this map, visit **this interactive map.**

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WORST	
State	**Percent**
Illinois	35.8%
Virginia	35.5%
Washington DC	35.1%
Louisiana	34.7%
North Carolina	34.2%
Arizona	34.1%
Alabama	33.2%
California	33.0%
Mississippi	32.0%
Alaska	31.8%
South Carolina	31.5%
Georgia	30.8%
Puerto Rico	12.8%

GOOD	
State	**Percent**
Oklahoma	44.4%
Rhode Island	44.4%
Utah	43.4%
Iowa	43.1%
Connecticut	42.8%
Delaware	42.3%
Indiana	41.3%
New Jersey	41.0%

Hawaii	40.9%
Maryland	40.8%
Missouri	40.6%
New York	40.2%
New Mexico	39.6%

Public Housing (Left side)

BEST	
State	**Percent**
Idaho	68.0%
New Hampshire	59.4%
Vermont	53.9%
Oregon	53.7%
Michigan	48.5%
Colorado	48.5%
Minnesota	48.4%
Washington	47.7%
Massachusetts	47.6%
Pennsylvania	46.8%
Wisconsin	45.4%
Maine	45.1%
South Dakota	44.6%

FAIR	
State	**Percent**
Wyoming	39.4%
Kentucky	39.4%
Arkansas	38.6%
Nevada	38.6%
Ohio	38.5%
West Virginia	38.1%

Texas	37.8%
Kansas	37.6%
Nebraska	37.5%
Florida	37.2%
Montana	36.8%
North Dakota	36.6%
Tennessee	36.1%

BEST	
State	**Percent**
Maine	61.8%
New Hampshire	61.8%
Utah	61.3%
Idaho	61.1%
Vermont	60.6%
New Mexico	57.0%
Washington	56.2%
Wyoming	55.9%
Oregon	55.4%
Montana	54.1%
North Dakota	52.9%
Alaska	52.6%
Iowa	51.4%

GOOD	
State	**Percent**
Colorado	51.2%
South Dakota	51.2%
California	50.8%
Wisconsin	50.8%

Nebraska	50.4%
Kansas	49.6%
Massachusetts	49.5%
Oklahoma	49.4%
Arizona	49.2%
West Virginia	48.0%
Nevada	47.6%
Michigan	47.4%
Arkansas	47.0%

FAIR	
State	**Percent**
New York	46.8%
Minnesota	46.6%
Ohio	46.4%
Pennsylvania	46.0%
Kentucky	45.4%
Missouri	45.0%
Indiana	44.8%
Rhode Island	44.5%
Maryland	43.6%
North Carolina	43.6%
Florida	43.3%
Virginia	42.9%

WORST	
State	**Percent**
Texas	41.2%
Delaware	41.2%
Hawaii	40.5%
Connecticut	40.3%

New Jersey	39.4%
Louisiana	39.0%
Tennessee	38.4%
Illinois	37.9%
South Carolina	37.5%
Georgia	36.8%
Washington DC	36.5%
Mississippi	34.4%
Alabama	33.2%
Puerto Rico	13.2%

Housing Choice Voucher (Right side)

[1]U.S. Department of Housing and Urban Development (HUD), PD&R, *A Picture of Subsidized Households (PSH)*, state totals (Summary Level 3), Public Housing (program=2) and Housing Choice Vouchers (program=3)

The Americans with Disabilities Act Participation Action Research Consortium (ADA-PARC) is a collaborative national project to document participation disparities experienced by people with disabilities at the national, state, and city levels. For more information on your state, visit ADAPARC.ORG. For more information about your rights, go to the ADA National Network ADATA.ORG. Please contact hammel@uic.edu if you have any questions.